

PLAIN LANGUAGE • EVERY CHAPTER OF LIFE

the money map.

whatever you're going through, it starts in the same place. **footing that's yours. your chapter's first three steps. a plan for the season you're in.** start anywhere — done beats perfect.

01

your footing

six things in your name

02

your chapter

the first three steps

03

your season

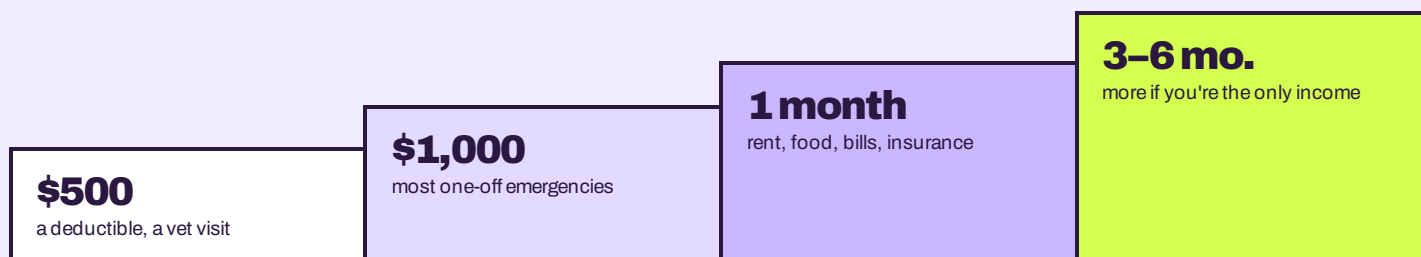
money, wherever you are

01 first, get your own footing.

six things that keep you on your own two feet at every stage. check them off one at a time, smallest first.

1	an account that's yours alone money you can reach without asking anyone. the most important line in this guide.	DO THIS open checking or savings in your name only, at a bank you picked. send part of every paycheck there.
2	copies of your documents proof of who you are, ready in an afternoon.	DO THIS ID, passport, social security card, birth certificate, tax returns, lease or deed, insurance — stored where only you can reach.
3	a cushion that's yours so a surprise — or a change — happens on your terms.	DO THIS build it in stages (below) in a high-yield savings account in your name.
4	credit in your own name a score that's yours, not borrowed from someone else's card.	DO THIS be the primary on one card, autopay the full balance, check free reports at annualcreditreport.com .
5	one number you know what comes in, what goes out, what you're worth.	DO THIS write down take-home, essentials, and net worth (own minus owe). check it once a month.
6	if you share money with someone the one most women skip — until they need it.	DO THIS know every account in the household, be on the deed or lease, keep a card in your own name, and know where the papers live.

THE CUSHION, IN STAGES — EACH STEP IS A REAL WIN



02 your first three steps.

find your chapter. do step 1 this week — the rest can wait. all 14 chapters live at multiplata.com/start.html

SOMETHING'S ENDING

i'm getting divorced

- 1 copy every statement + 3 years of tax returns
- 2 open an account in your name only; pull your credit report
- 3 list what you own and owe; check beneficiaries before signing

SOMETHING'S ENDING

i need to leave — quietly

- 1 safety first: call 800-799-7233 or text START to 88788
- 2 copy your documents; keep them where only you can reach
- 3 start money that's only yours — even \$20 at a time

SOMETHING'S ENDING

my partner died

- 1 most big decisions can wait a few months
- 2 order several certified death certificates
- 3 call social security about survivor benefits

STARTING NEW

i'm going back to work

- 1 write down what you did while away — it counts
- 2 know your number before the first interview
- 3 negotiate the first offer; every raise builds on it

STARTING NEW

i'm starting over from zero

- 1 an account in your name + your free credit reports
- 2 build credit on purpose: a secured card, paid in full
- 3 cushion in stages: \$500 → \$1,000 → one month

STARTING NEW

i'm starting a business

- 1 test the idea; separate business money from day one
- 2 sole proprietor or LLC, plus a free EIN from the IRS
- 3 set aside ~25–30% of what you earn for taxes

TAKING CARE

i'm raising kids on my own

- 1 file head of household; up to \$2,200 per child
- 2 name a guardian in a will; check beneficiaries
- 3 build a bigger cushion — you're the only income

IT JUST HAPPENED

i came into money

- 1 park it in high-yield savings; wait 30 days
- 2 pay off high-interest debt first
- 3 then decide — with a fee-only advisor if it's big

FREE HELP YOU'RE ENTITLED TO

most women don't know these exist — or assume they don't qualify. ask anyway.

211

call or visit 211.org — local help with housing, food, utilities, childcare

legal aid

free lawyers if your income qualifies — lawhelp.org

free tax prep

IRS volunteer (VITA) sites — search "VITA" at irs.gov

benefits

SNAP, WIC, Medicaid, CHIP, unemployment — usa.gov/benefit-finder

03

your money,
by season.

find the season you're in. you'll move between them — that's normal, not failure.

SEASON 1

survival

when essentials eat most of what comes in.

- **essentials first:** housing, food, utilities, transportation, childcare.
- **protect even \$10 a week** in an account that's only yours.
- **use every free resource** — 211, benefits, free tax prep (page 02).
- **call before you miss a payment.** ask for a hardship plan — many lenders have one.

you're done when: \$500 is set aside.

SEASON 2

steady

when the bills are covered with some left over.



- **future-you money moves first**, on payday, automatically.
- **fill the cushion** to one month of essentials.
- **pay down high-interest debt** — it outruns almost any investment.

you're done when: no card debt + one month saved.

SEASON 3

building

when you're ready for money that grows.

- **grab any 401(k) match** — it's part of your pay.
- **a Roth IRA in your own name.** home with kids? a **spousal IRA** lets a working spouse fund one for you if you file jointly.
- **low-cost index funds**, then leave them alone. time does the work.
- **protect your income:** disability insurance, and life insurance if anyone depends on you.

keep going: 3–6 months saved, investing every month.

windfall?

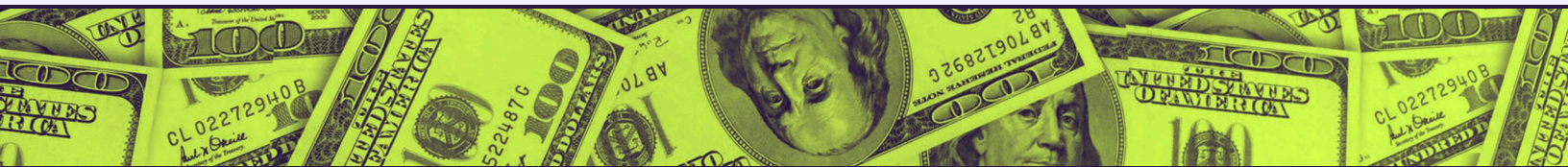
any season: park it in high-yield savings and give yourself 30 days. then kill high-interest debt, then decide — with a fee-only advisor if it's big.

MY SEASON RIGHT NOW

☐ survival ☐ steady ☐ building

my next move:

one thing, this week.



there's a whole library behind this map.

every chapter, every word decoded — free, plain language, nothing to sell you.

multiplata.com →